

Transpose Text

Operation	Keystroke	Function	Note
Transpose (swap) text elements	Emacs supports the following commands that swap a text element with the preceding one. • PEL provides extra key bindings, available for convenience and discovery via which-key. The Emacs native keys are shorter. • PEL also provides key bindings for more native Emacs commands.		
Last updated on:	2026-09-20		
Open this PDF file. See also: 🔗 Help/Info	<f11> t t <f1>	(pel-help-pdf &optional OPEN-WEB-PAGE)	Open the 🔗 Transpose local PDF. With C-u , M-- , M- -1 or C- -1 prefix: open the remote GitHub hosted PDF instead. If the pel-flip-help-pdf-arg user-option is set it's the other way around.
Transpose two characters	• C-t • <f11> t t c	(transpose-chars ARG)	Interchange characters around point, moving forward one character. • With prefix arg ARG, effect is to take character before point and drag it forward past ARG other characters (backward if ARG negative). • If no argument and at end of line, the previous two chars are exchanged.
Transpose two words	• M-t • <f11> t t w	(transpose-words ARG)	Interchange words around point, leaving point at end of them. • With prefix arg ARG, effect is to take word before or around point and drag it forward past ARG other words (backward if ARG negative). • If ARG is zero, the words around or after point and around or after mark are interchanged. To use: put cursor between 2 words to transpose. • After transposition emacs leaves the cursor after the second word. • Emacs transpose words, but not punctuation. The concept of word is, however, flexible because it is controlled by Emacs syntax tables. 👉 See Emacs Text - Words section for more information on how to operate on words with Emacs. Also see 🔗 Text Modes .
Transpose two sub-words • subword-mode must be on • 2 words can be separated by dash, underscore or the 2 parts of a camelCase word. • See: 🔗 Text Modes	<f11> t t W	(subword-transpose ARG)	Do the same as ‘transpose-words’ but on subwords. • See the command ‘subword-mode’ in 🔗 Text Modes for a description of subwords. • Optional argument ARG is the same as for ‘transpose-words’. 👉 Use this transpose words when the subword-mode is active. Useful to transpose words separated by dash, underscores or camelCase words.
Transpose two lines	• C-x C-t • <f11> t t l	(transpose-lines ARG)	Exchange current line and previous line, leaving point after both. • With argument ARG, takes previous line and moves it past ARG lines. • With argument 0, interchanges line point is in with line mark is in. To use: put cursor to the second line.
Transpose two balanced expressions (sexps)	• C-M-t • <f11> t t x	(transpose-sexps ARG)	Transpose 2 balanced expressions (text enclosed in parenthesis, braces, square or angle brackets, quotes, back-quotes and double quotes) of the same of different types. Here they are globally identified as <i>sexpr</i> . • Unlike ‘transpose-words’, point must be between the two sexps and not in the middle of a sexp to be transposed. • With non-zero prefix arg ARG, effect is to take the sexp before point and drag it forward past ARG other sexps (backward if ARG is negative). • If ARG is zero, the sexps ending at or after point and at or after mark are interchanged.
Transpose two sentences	<f11> t t s	(transpose-sentences ARG)	Interchange the current sentence with the next one. • With prefix argument ARG a non-zero integer, moves the current sentence past ARG sentences, leaving point after the current sentence. • If ARG is positive, moves the current sentence forwards, if ARG is negative moves it backwards. If ARG is zero, exchanges the current sentence with the one containing the mark. Note that by default sentences must be separated by end of line or 2 space characters. The number of space characters required can be modified. The PEL package provides the (pel-toggle-sentence-end) command, bound to <f11> t m s to toggle the value from 2 to 1. See the Text Modes table. 👉 See Emacs Text - Sentences section for more information on how Emacs defines a sentence and the commands dealing with them.
Transpose two paragraphs	<f11> t t p	(transpose-paragraphs ARG)	Interchange the current paragraph with the next one. • With prefix argument ARG a non-zero integer, moves the current paragraph past ARG paragraphs, leaving point after the current paragraph. • If ARG is positive, moves the current paragraph forwards, if ARG is negative moves it backwards. If ARG is zero, exchanges the current paragraph with the one containing the mark. 👉 See Emacs Text - Paragraphs section for more information on how Emacs define a paragraph and the commands dealing with them.
Transpose 2 regions	<f11> t t r	(transpose-regions STARTR1 ENDR1 STARTR2 ENDR2 &optional LEAVE-MARKERS)	Transpose region STARTR1 to ENDR1 with STARTR2 to ENDR2. • The regions should not be overlapping, because the size of the buffer is never changed in a transposition. • Optional fifth arg LEAVE-MARKERS, if non-nil, means don’t update any markers that happen to be located in the regions. • Transposing beyond buffer boundaries is an error. • Interactively, STARTR1 and ENDR1 are point and mark; STARTR2 and ENDR2 are the last two marks pushed to the mark ring; LEAVE-MARKERS is nil. • If a prefix argument N is given, STARTR2 and ENDR2 are the two successive marks N entries back in the mark ring. • A negative prefix argument instead counts forward from the oldest mark in the mark ring. To use interactively: 1. First move point at the beginning of the first region. 2. Type C-SPC and move point to the end of the first region. 3. Type C-g 4. Move point to the beginning of the second region. 5. Type C-SPC and move point to the end of the second region. 6. Execute the command.

Transpose — References

Topic & Link	Notes
GNU Emacs Manual: Fixit - Transposing Text	
GNU Emacs Manual: Text - Words	
GNU Emacs Manual: Text - Sentences	
GNU Emacs Manual: Text - Paragraphs	